

THE DESCENT
OF
THE BRANCH,
INTO THE
WATERS OF SORROW
TO BRING UP
The Election of Grace

by

John Church

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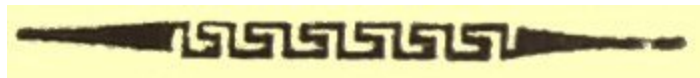
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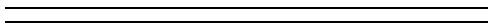
BEING THE SUBSTANCE OF
A Sermon,

PREACHED BY
J. CHURCH,
OF THE SURREY TABERNACLE.



“AND HE CRIED UNTO THE LORD, AND THE LORD SHEWED HIM A
TREE, WHICH WHEN HE HAD CAST INTO THE WATERS, THE
WATERS WERE MADE SWEET.”

“AND IF WE ARE AFFLICTED IT IS FOR YOUR CONSOLATION.”



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1817.

A Sermon.

2 KINGS, 6th Chap. v. 6.

And the Man of God said, Where fell it? And he shewed him the place, and he cut down a stick, and cast it in thither, and the iron did swim.

ALL scripture is written for our instruction in the knowledge of the Person and Work of God our dear Saviour, as the only foundation of our hope, the object of our faith and love, the only refuge of guilty man, the brightness of the Father's glory, and the express image of his love, his wisdom, and his infinite condescension. Holy men of old spake, and wrote the sacred scriptures, under the divine influence of the Holy Ghost. Christ is the main object they all believed in, looked to, hoped for, and held forth to succeeding generations. Christ is the substance of the whole Bible; every passage, in some way or other, like the Star of Bethlehem, points to him; and the most wise and spiritual children of the Most High, as divinely taught, must be ever upon the look-out for Jesus in every part of the divine word. Christ is in every doctrine, in every sacred illustrious character, in every type, in every ordinance, and in every precept, in every promise, and every Old Testament history, as well as every New Testament parable: and where the mind is sweetly influenced by the love of Jesus, it gladly receives Christ wherever it is given by the Spirit to see him.

I would not be wise above what is written, nor would I attempt to force the meaning of the blessed Spirit, or misapply it to answer any purpose; but I must humbly beg to remark, that in reading the circumstance which I have selected for a text, my mind was at first forcibly struck with the account; and looking up for wisdom to preach on it, and having been favored with the gracious presence of my Lord in handling it, I could no longer suppress my own feelings, with the earnest solicitations of many that heard it, who were apparently blessed by this feeble testimony, I present it in the simple

form, as in part preached. I have tried to retain the substance, though I am not able to write verbatim, what was delivered: I only aim at setting forth the glory of the dear Saviour, as held forth in this passage, to the Church; that by comparing spiritual truths with spiritual experiences, some of God's tried people may be built up in their most holy faith, and sweetly led to see that they have not believed in vain.

We find in this history, that the Spirit of Prophecy in the Church was increasing in the land; this was doubtless a favourable sign, for *where there is no vision the people perish*; and truly happy is that land which abounds in spiritual ministers, spiritual ordinances, and spiritual people. The increase of Prophets rendered it necessary that they should be convened together, for the promotion of each other's knowledge and comfort. We find there was a College of them at Gilgal, over which the prophet Elisha was a President, in the room of his Predecessor Elijah. We would, indeed, humbly hope, this College of Prophets, was a blessing to the Church, and that the Candidates for the Ministry were really moved by the Holy Ghost, to take upon them that sacred office; but, alas! in those days was Gehazi, and others, who, it is to be feared, never were taught either Law or Gospel, experimentally; and may we not adopt the old Church Service, and exclaim, with grief of heart, *As it was in the beginning is now?* But our most blessed Lord will do all his will, perform all his gracious purposes, and as the great Head of the Church, and Saviour of the body, he must bring all his redeemed to the knowledge of himself, and at last home to glory, by all the means his own infinite wisdom has planned, whether they are educated at a Collage, or not. Human learning is a blessing to the Church, when sanctified; but most mere letter-learned men, like Pilate, fix their Hebrew, Greek, and Latin upon the head of Christ, instead of laying it at his feet, as Paul did. Most probably the College of Gilgal was at this time full, so that some of the Sons of the Prophets asked leave to go to Jordan, and reside there—we are informed of the reason of this request, in the first of this chapter. Their piety, humility, and industry are evident. The matter was laid before Elisha and before the Lord, by him; so should God's dear ministers and people ever act—for *in the multitude of counsellors there is safety*; and hence that very important advice, *In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths*. The humility of their minds is as clearly revealed; they did not desire a mansion, or even an elegant college, but only an humble cot—a little, with the fear

and love of God, is far, yea, infinitely preferable to great riches. The main study of ministers should be usefulness; great riches seldom promote much spirituality in ministers or people: those who are running an heavenly race, should not load themselves with thick clay. The gospel ministry is called a warfare, and an aged father in the church, observes to his son Timothy, *No man that warreth should entangle himself in the affairs of this life*—that is, if he can avoid it.

Not only the piety and humility of these good men are evident, but their industry; not to be burdensome to any, they went to work themselves, in the thicket, near the river Jordan, the resort of wild beasts; but the appointed path of duty, is, in general, the place of safety; here the Lord had directed them, and being in *his* way, he doubtless honoured them with *his* protecting, supporting, and approving smile.—Elisha was with them, superintending their affairs, and entreating the Lord for their success. This act, thus recorded by the divine Spirit, of the conduct of the Prophets, in cutting down the thickets of trees, and building an House, might perhaps have brought to their minds, the work to which they were called, and for which they were preparing.—Sinners are called Trees; the Gospel is compared to an Axe; Ministers are called Labourers; and if they find but little success in their work, they are directed to Jesus for strength, and to the blessed Spirit for wisdom to aim right. Perhaps Solomon alludes to this, when he says, *If the Iron be blunt, he must put to the more strength; but wisdom is profitable to direct*.—Agreeable to this is the language of our Lord to his Disciples, when fishing; he said, *Follow we, and I will make you fishers of men*. Thus instructed by Jesus, they could spiritualize their employment as fishers. This World is called a Sea, the Church a Ship, Men are compared to Fish, Ministers to fishermen, and the Gospel to a Net cast into the Sea; thus our dear Lord improved any circumstance, for the instruction of his dear people.

It appears, the Prophets were not ashamed to handle an hammer, or an axe, nor did their Master forbid it; they were mechanics, as well as preachers. The Lord has often called the meanest of men to the highest office in the Church of God, and made them eminently useful: David from keeping Sheep; Elisha from the Plough's-tail; Amos from gathering Sycamore-fruit; the Apostles from their Barges; and those Prophets to handle the axe, the saw, and the hammer. Their work as Carpenters and Builders, serves to remind them of their spiritual occupation—and it is worthy of observation,

that when the Holy Spirit shewed Zechariah in vision, of the future opposition that would be made against the kingdom of Jesus, in the Gospel Dispensation, he shewed him four Horns, and after that, he shewed him four Carpenters, who were to fray them, cut them down; and such were the Apostles and Ministers of the Gospel in the four parts of the World; who were to fell trees, cut them down, lay them low, fit them, square them according to God's Word, and thus build them up an habitation for God, through the Spirit.

Our text relates, that as one was felling a Beam, the head of his Axe fell into the water; (most probably into Jordan). This was a grief to him, for the reason he assigned, so that he cried to Elisha, and said, *Alas, master, for it is borrowed!* Possessing a spirit of honesty, and being too poor to make it good to the lender, he applied to Elisha, not to work a miracle, that we can tell, but because the man's Axe was sunk, and the Prophet's work stopped. Thus, ministers have constantly something to try them in their work; they well know the world is always ready to reproach them, and the glorious cause they espouse, which fills them with grief, but leads them to the dear Saviour, to appear in the love of his heart, and in the power of his arm, for their deliverance, who always kindly assures them his grace is sufficient for them. Some have conjectured that this man was an hypocrite, or a figure of all false preachers, who run unsent of God; who preach a borrowed experience, a borrowed system of religion; who are only in the letter, and not in the spirit; of whose religion and preaching, like the poor man's Axe, it may be truly said, *Alas! master, for it was borrowed.* And hence God threatens the Prophets, that steal his words from others, and declares they shall not profit this people at all; nor can unconverted, graceless preachers profit the experimental children of God. A preacher must be taught the plague of his own heart, the spirituality of God's Law, the value of a precious Jesus, in his Person and Work, by God the Spirit, before he can be useful to the Church. We must first know, then speak what we know, as the Apostle says, *We can but speak of the things which we have seen, and we are his witnesses.* Many may borrow words from real saints, and may appear like believers indeed; nor can even the brightest saint at all times tell a hypocrite from a saint, but the day will declare it—*then, then shall ye return, and discern between the righteous and the wicked*—a mere borrowed religion will let the soul sink in death, but the free gift of God is

eternal life—locked up in Christ, manifested by the Spirit, and leads the soul to rest, live, and rejoice alone in the everlasting love of God, the free, unmerited grace of an everlasting covenant, the glorious person, and finished work of Christ, as its all in all.

The Prophet seeing the situation of his pupil, cut down a stick from a tree, and cast it into the water, when behold a most astonishing miracle appears—the stick, contrary to its native tendency, sunk, and brought up the iron head of the axe, which swam, contrary to its natural gravitation.—The man no doubt joyfully received it, and went on with his work. What cannot, what will not the God of Israel do for his people, to shew he is the Lord their God, that they are his servants, and that they are acting agreeable to his will. The Lord confirmeth the work of his servants and frustrateth the tokens of liars; and surely the petition of Elijah is exactly adapted, in many cases, to God's dear ministers, when he prayed, and said, *Lord God, let it be known this day that I am thy servant, that this is thy people, and that I have done all these things according to thy word.*

Our text reads thus: *But as one was felling a beam, the axe head fell into the water; and he cried, and said, Alas! Master, for it was borrowed. And the man of God said, Where fell it? And he shewed him the place. And he cut down a stick and cast it in thither, and the iron did swim—therefore said he, take it up to thee, and he put out his hand, and took it.*

In further considering this most instructive subject, I would take occasion to notice our fall and recovery, in the two heads; Adam, the sinful head and representative of all mankind; and the adorable Jesus, the elect head of his dear people. It is a solemn and a glorious truth, that as in Adam all die, so in Christ shall all be made alive. Or, as the learned say it is literally in the Greek, All in Adam die; all in Christ shall be made alive. Here are the two heads, and no more—the one represents all mankind—the second Adam, all his children given to him, loved, redeemed, and saved by him. Much has been said and written on the subject of the Fall of Man: great indeed was that Fall, and dreadful has been the consequences of it. All the miseries in earth and hell are the consequences of it. Alas! how deeply fallen is man into the mire of corruption, sin, and folly; and into the waters of deep affliction—sunk, as iron cast or dropped into the waters of Jordan, which naturally gravitates to its own centre. Our nature was sunk so deep, that it

was apparently lost, and so incapacitated, that it has no more power to come up out of it, than iron has to swim of itself, independent of a miracle—covered over, sunk in earth, yea, the Apostle asserts, it is earthly, sensual, and devilish; having fallen from wisdom, and become foolish; from righteousness, and become a criminal; from holiness, and become impure; and from happy freedom, to awful bondage. The powers of the soul, all the noble talents that were only lent; these are awfully depraved, yea, so evil, that I am bold to assert, no man can believe he is as vile as the Bible declares him, till he is put in the possession of the faith of God's elect. There requires as much divine power, to credit the state of man, as to believe in the salvation of the soul. The same faith the holy Spirit gives to see Jesus, believe in Jesus, and rest on Jesus, is required to believe the desperate depravity of the human heart. The same light in which I see the new man, I see the old; in the same teaching I see truth, I discover the aboundings of error, and by the same anointing I behold my standing in the second Adam, I see my fall in the first. But it is well for the people of God, who are acquainted with their fallen natures, that the holy Spirit leads them to see the glorious remedy in the gospel; that as the Law enters, sin being discovered, weakness felt, corruption a burden, misery groaned under, and the awful consequences deplored. The Gospel is so highly esteemed by such persons, and none know the value of the Gospel, but those who feel their sins, and see them in the light of the Law, as deserving the wrath of a holy God; and finding the utter impossibility of keeping the Law, in thought, word, or deed—that the law condemns most justly for a sinful thought, as well as a sinful action. Hence the dear Redeemer, in his grand Sermon on the Mount, preached this Law in its spirituality, and insisted upon it, that anger in the heart against another without cause, was murder; and a lustful glance of the eye, adultery. Truly believing this testimony from the word, and by the teaching of the Spirit out of the Law, we must exclaim, What flesh can be saved? The scripture answers, (and all the election of grace is brought to believe it) *Therefore by the deeds of the Law shall no flesh be justified in his sight.* But it is the grand design of the Gospel, to open to a poor sinner, the glorious plan of salvation, by the joint work of the ever adorable trinity in unity. And it is the business of gospel ministers, to be ever stating the precious truths of the Gospel, and pointing poor guilty man to the blessed means whereby he can be justified and pardoned. This leads me to notice the conduct of the Prophet; when the

man cried on account of his loss to him, he cut down a stick, and cast it in thither, and the iron did swim. Many great events were done at Jordan, it divided when the Israelites were to pass over to Canaan. As soon as the Ark, borne upon the shoulders of the priests, made its appearance, the waters parted. Hence the Psalmist asks, *What ailed thee, O thou Sea, that thou fleddest, and thou Jordan, that thou wast driven back.* Another text answers, *The waters saw thee, O God, in the midst of Jordan.* Joshua set up twelve stones in remembrance of the surprising event. Jacob passed over it twice, once with a heavy disconsolate heart, in leaving his home—and twenty years after, he passed the same place, and called to remembrance the gracious conduct of his God; *with this Staff I passed over Jordan, and now I am become two bands.* Elijah and Elisha smote the waters of Jordan with the same Mantle, but the most distinguished honour that was ever conferred on Jordan, was the descent of the lovely Son of God into them, by the ordinance of baptism, when the adorable Spirit alighted upon him, visible, though in the manner in which a Dove hovers in its descent; and Jesus was anointed to enter into his great work, while the Father bore testimony to him as his beloved Son, in whom he rested, pleased with him, and all his dear people in him. In the waters of Jordan the Axe head fell, and gravitating to its centre, sunk deep, no doubt, in the mire at the bottom, but a stick is cut down, cast in, sinks deep, and brings up the head, by causing it to swim—this was the means; and who can read this circumstance with attention, but must be reminded of him, who is the stem of Jesse, who was so many years typified by the rod of Moses, who performed so many wonders for the children of Israel, and is, in a certain sense, doing the same for his people in the wilderness to this day. He was also typified by the rod of Aaron, which budded, blossomed, and yielded almonds—to all human appearance, a very unpromising object, a dry stick. This is he, of whom the prophet Isaiah spake, perhaps in allusion to Aaron's rod, *He shall come up before him like a tender plant, and as a root out of a dry ground;* to all human appearance, a very unlikely person to be the Messiah, the Saviour of men. But another chapter holds forth his qualifications, *And there shall come forth a rod out of the stem of Jesse, and a branch shall grow out of his root.* So says the Lord by another Prophet, *Behold my servant, the Branch.* And the Lord again, by Ezekiel, says, *I will take off the top of his branch a young twig, and I will set it, and under his branches shall dwell all fowl of every wing.* And perhaps, in allusion to this, the dear Saviour compares

himself to a grain of mustard seed, small when sown, but large when grown, so that the birds of the air lodge in the branches thereof. This was to shew the reality of his human nature, his amazing condescension, his deep abasement, and the meanness of his descent. As man, humbled himself to the form of a servant, and as the saviour of the body, of which he is the head, the Father called him to the great work of redemption, and said, *Thou art my servant, O Israel, in whom I will be glorified*. He gave him to the church, to deliver it from the ruins of the fall, and, as a Branch, he was cut off from the land of the living. Hence the prediction, *Messiah shall be cut off, but not for himself*. He was indeed cut off from the synagogue of the Jews, from the carnal worldling, and from the proud Pharisee. He was cut off from his own relatives, from his own dear disciples for a time, from every earthly comfort and convenience, and cut off from the land of the living, by a most violent, painful, and shameful death; *for the transgression of my people was he stricken*. He was cast into the deep waters. He had been baptized in water at Jordan—now he must be baptized in blood, and sweet, and tears. Hence his deep afflictions are called waters; and he sighed and said, *Save me O God, the waters are come in unto my soul. I sink in deep mire. I am come into deep waters, where the floods overflow me. Deliver me out of the deep waters, and out of the mire. Let me be delivered from them that hate me*. Hence we see our dear Lord sinking with the blood of our guilt, bearing our sins, sustaining our curse, and enduring the hell that we had merited—

He sunk beneath our heavy woes,
To raise us to his throne.

This tells his gracious design to fetch us up from destruction, to make atonement for all our transgressions, to fulfil all the Law's demands, to satisfy the justice of God, to harmonize every divine attribute, to redeem his dear people from the curse, to open a way of access to God, to sanctify every temporal blessing, to incense the gift of the Holy Ghost, and that our old man might be crucified, that the whole body of death might be destroyed, to conquer sin, to subdue Satan, to bar the mouth of hell, to rend the vail of the temple, to open the pearly gates of the celestial city, to remove spiritual death, to take away the sting of temporal death, to finish transgression, make an end of sin, bring in an everlasting righteousness,

make reconciliation for iniquity, and to make himself an everlasting name; and he must, he shall have, all the glory, from first to last. Thus Jews died for these grand purposes—death is our life; he hath raised us up in himself, raised up our poor fallen natures indeed; and by virtue of his work we are restored to the image of God in regeneration, to communion with God in conversion, and to the likeness of Christ in our resurrection. Glory be to his dear name for stooping so low to raise us so high; nor will he ever give over the wonders of his grace till we are raised out of the mire of corruption, indwelling sin, and out of the waters of all affliction; for the Lord will perfect his begun good work, for his mercy endureth for ever.

Thus we see our fall, and our recovery in Christ. Not that the dear people of God, in one sense, ever fell out of the flavour of God, or were ever liable to be damned; but the nature of sin in God's people is the same as in the reprobate, and requires an infinite satisfaction—this being given a free proclamation is issued out to all who feel their need of this Jesus; they are welcome to him, and he has graciously assured such he will in no wise cast them out—and this is a promise worth a thousand worlds, and gladly accepted by them that believe, *That Jesus Christ came into the world to save sinners.*—Praise ye the Lord.

There is one thought more worthy our attention as the people of God. When the Apostle enumerates the vast privileges of God's dear children, as one with Christ, the property of Christ, as Christ is God's—he infers that the ministry of the Gospel is none of the smallest in the inventory: *all are yours, whether Paul or Cephas*—implying that the calling and qualification of ministers is for the Church: and the Apostle adds, in another place, that even the very afflictions of the ministers are for the Church. Hence, he says, *If we be afflicted it is for your consolation.* And again, *All things are for your sakes.* So then death worketh in us, but life in you. For this cause we faint not. As a Candle which burneth, consumeth away itself to give light to others, so it is true of ministers; they are quickened by the Spirit, united to Jesus, love his person, name, and work, his truths, his people, and his ways. And being called into public life, by the great head of the church, they are cut off from the world and its maxims, its religion, and its bare form the power. They are cast into many waters of affliction; they are plunged deep, even into the mire, to bring up some poor soul by their instrumentality. Why are they led to feel more deep the depravity of the

human heart, but that they might be able to describe its workings. Why are they so deeply exercised with the discipline of the Law, but that they might describe the cases of them who are under its workings, and so often liable to a spirit of bondage. Why have they uncommon temptations from the adversary, but that they, like their divine Lord, might sympathize with the tempted, and being well acquainted with Satan's devices, that they might expose them. Why cast down because of the troubles of the way, but that they might seek only to Jesus; that they might learn, experimentally, how to make use of a precious Saviour, as exactly adapted for such cases. Why more reproached. Why more exposed to temptations. Why is Satan more busy with them. Why, perhaps, more tried in their families; plagued with erroneous characters of every description; tried in the world; perplexed in the church; in perils often among false brethren; exercised in mind, with the sins of professors; the weakness of God's own dear children; the envy of their own brethren; and the aboundings of iniquity and error in the World. The fears of not being called to the work aright; the little success they meet with; their dead seasons in the pulpit; and the very little progress in the Church among God's children, in their knowledge of divine things. The instability of their hearers; the cruel criticisms, uncharitable reflections, and unpleasant speeches, mixed with the contempt of the proud. The apostacy of some from the truth, after a blazing profession, and professing to be called under our ministry; with the envy of poor niggardly professors, who, perhaps, never gave a shilling to the cause of Jesus, yet grudge every good thing the Lord gives them, and they receive with the sanction of the great head of the church, the heir of all things. These, and many more afflictions the dear ministers of the sanctuary experience. Oh! if many pious young men, who are anxious for the ministry, even from the best of motives, if they could foresee what they would pass through before they finish their course, they would venture forward with more trembling steps than they do. These trials made one of the greatest preachers (next to our dear Lord himself) exclaim, *Who is sufficient for these things?* But glory be to Jesus, our sufferings are of God, and our trials are not merely for ourselves, as believers, but for the sake of God's dear children. We are often cast into these deep waters, to dive after some who have sunk very low in soul, either in the waters of affliction, or in the deep mire of known, felt, lamented, and painful corruptions. This teaching made Paul understand all things, and all men: if he met with a soul in deep terrors, he could describe their state, and

point out their feelings, having known the terrors of the Lord. If in bondage, if filled with fears, if depressed in soul, if exercised with fiery darts, if fearful of falling away, if fallen into sin, if distressed with a load of trials, if persecuted, reproached, apparently forsaken, and dejected, he knows how to prescribe the remedy, as well as to describe the state, both is a mercy—and to be led by the divine Spirit, to be deeply acquainted with sin and its miseries, with Jesus and his salvation, experimentally; to be called, and enabled to preach both, with the testimony of God to the soul, is a mercy for a minister; and what is he without such teaching? For the whole design of the Spirit, leading to all the miseries of our fallen nature, is but to endear Christ, and that we might prize the precious truths of the Gospel, as they exhibit to us the only remedy for all our woes; the mystery of the adorable trinity in unity, with the several covenant acts of love to the election of grace; the glorious undertaking of our adorable surety; the exact suitability of Jesus; his infinite birth, his infinite life of obedience, his most wonderful death, his glorious resurrection, his prevalent intercession, his covenant engagements, his precious promises, his gracious presence, his astonishing pity, his boundless compassion, his free grace, his saving offices, his glorious perfections, his mediatorial glories, his sweet titles, his precious characters, and his numerous appearances for his church. These clearly stated to God's chosen, without the mixture of free-will, human performances, or any of the effects of old Adam's nature, will be owned and blessed to God's own children, their glorious remedy for every malady; while the faithful minister will be led to see the gracious design of his God, in permitting him to feel, and leading him into deep waters.

I conclude by observing once more on this subject, that all the Lord's children are the subjects of many sinkings of soul, arising from inbred sin, felt guilt, lamented depravity, heavy trials, sore besetments, family troubles, and grievous backslidings. The holy Spirit is always carrying on his own work, by leading us daily to see and feel what we are, as sinners, in the first Adam's head; and what we are, as saints, in Christ Jesus, the second Adam, the Lord from heaven. This is blessed teaching, it leads from all self-righteousness, self-wisdom, self-dependance, and self-adulation; it leads alone to the dear God-man Mediator, as the glorious fountain of untreated good, as the centre of a believing soul, and as its eternal all in all. The teachings of the Spirit, though accompanied with numerous trials, known

only to those who are taught of God, are, at the same time, sweet evidences of our eternal election, divine predestination, gracious adoption, compleat justification, and eternal pardon. And the holy Spirit has engaged to act as a gracious comforter in the soul, to fetch us up when sunk in sorrow, dismay, and despair; and will put this sweet song in our mouths, *He brought me up also out of the horrible pit and mirey clay*. And he will also quicken our mortal bodies, and bring us up again from the territories of the grave; for the Lord said, *I will bring again from Bashan; I will bring my people up again from the depths of the Sea*.

FINIS.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE DESCENT OF
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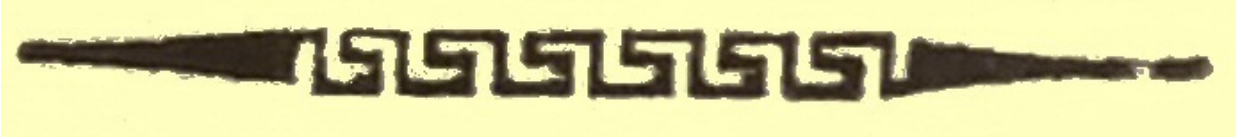
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